ICH Harmonised Tripartite Guideline: Pharmaceutical Quality System (ICH Q10)

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1. Scope and Relationship to Regional Requirements

This guideline describes a model for an effective quality management system for the pharmaceutical industry, referred to as the Pharmaceutical Quality System. ICH Q10 applies to the systems supporting the development and manufacture of pharmaceutical drug substances and drug products.

ICH Q10 supplements regional GMP requirements and provides a comprehensive approach across the entire product lifecycle from pharmaceutical development to product discontinuation.

Implementation of ICH Q10 enhances product quality, supports innovation, and strengthens the link between development and commercial manufacturing.

2. Management Responsibility and Governance

Senior management has the ultimate responsibility to ensure an effective Pharmaceutical Quality System is in place to achieve the quality objectives, and that roles, responsibilities, and authorities are defined, communicated, and implemented throughout the company.

Management should participate directly in quality planning, provide adequate resources, and conduct periodic management reviews of process performance and product quality.

3. Continual Improvement of Process Performance and Product Quality

Pharmaceutical companies should plan and execute a system for monitoring process performance and product quality to ensure a state of control is maintained. Key elements include process performance and product quality monitoring system, CAPA system, change management system, and management review.

A proactive CAPA system ensures root cause eradication, while systematic change control preserves the validated state of equipment and processes.

4. Knowledge Management and Quality Risk Management Enablers

Enablers of ICH Q10 include Knowledge Management and Quality Risk Management. These enablers facilitate a science- and risk-based approach to product lifecycle and quality system implementation.

Knowledge management facilitates continuous learning and prevents loss of institutional wisdom across personnel transitions.